

THE SECOND HEARTH

By [Your Name]

A TTRPG Expansion

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The women who wash the dead do not sing.

They count.

One for the breath that left,

Two for the name that stays,

Three for the grief they will carry home.

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The weary sister knelt beside her lady's bed. The birth had gone wrong. Twins. The boy drew his first breath; the girl's stilled before it could begin. The mother's breath would soon follow. The Cord demanded the price: a memory, a name, a last breath. But the lady... had held her hand when no one else would. She learned the herb craft and had a gift for knots. She had asked for nothing. So she cut the thread—not to collect, but to let go. The price was terrible.

The Smell of Thyme

They burned the orchard first. Thyme grows back. Girls don't.

—Quinn, age twelve, before she forgot her name

I. The Root Cellar

The smell of thyme is the last thing Quinn remembers clearly—crushed between her mother's fingers, sharp and green against the morning sun that gilded the eastern wall stones. *Thyme for courage*, her mother had whispered, pressing a sprig into Quinn's palm. *Thyme for memory*.

Then the torches crested the hill.

Quinn is twelve, small-boned and sharp-eyed, with a mage's knot like a bruise behind her left ear she's never learned to name. She hears the death-scream of wheat when fire nears—a useless gift until the wheat screams *now*, a high, tearing sound that means the Chain-Lanterns are close.

The Lanterns move with the practiced silence of butchers: five figures in iron-mesh hoods, their leader's gloved hand flashing a wax-sealed writ as he kicks in the door. No knock.

Just the splinter of wood and her mother's calm voice cutting bread at the table.

Where is the girl?

Her mother says nothing. She is good at nothing—this is the first gift a village witch gives her daughter: the ability to become furniture, to vanish into the grain of a chair or the weave of a rug while the world rages outside.

Quinn is already in the root cellar, the door hidden behind drying sage and mugwort. She counts breaths—eight, never nine, because nine is for the Hollow that waits in the dark between heartbeats. Through floorboard cracks, she sees the glint of a Lantern's bell. One ring before accusation. Three before burning. She's heard this bell in nightmares since she was six. Now it's real, and it's coming for her.

II. Old Mira's Last Lesson

The village witch, Old Mira, isn't surprised. She's been expecting the Lanterns since autumn, when a neighbor's boy swore he heard Quinn whispering to a frost-blackened apple tree—and the tree whispered back. Mira already sent word to the Breath-less: a cracked bowl on her north step, a red thread knotted tight around the well rope.

She finds Quinn in the cellar as the first thatch ignites. Smoke curls down the stairs, smelling of rosemary and panic.

Mira doesn't ask. She presses three things into Quinn's

trembling hands: a stick of chalk, a knot of scarlet thread, and a name that isn't hers. *You are not Quinn anymore. You are Thyme. And you will run.*

The Lanterns' leader hauls Mira into the village square, where the scent of burning thyme already hangs thick and sweet. They don't burn her yet—Inquisition loves procedure. *Where is the girl? Name her true name.*

Mira stares at the smoke pouring from the orchard. The thyme is feeding the fire. She smiles, brittle as old bark.

She is already gone. And you will not remember her face.

It's no spell. It's a curse Mira's been weaving for forty years—in every bowl of soup for the feverish, every whispered *I'm here* at a deathbed, every child she caught as they slipped into the world. All thread. Now she pulls it taut.

The Lantern leader blinks. He knows Mira's face, Quinn's mother's face—but the daughter's? It slips from his grip like water through sieve fingers. He writes *girl, approximately twelve, dark hair* in his ledger. Even as the ink bleeds, he knows it's not enough.

III. The Covens' Road

Quinn—she will learn to answer to Thyme, but not yet—runs through the orchard. Thyme smoke is thick and green, clinging to her skin like second smoke, masking her scent. Behind her, the village screams: timber cracking, a cow's bel-

low cut short. Ahead, only the dark and the promise of the ford.

The first safe house is a charcoal-burner's hut, three miles into the wood's belly. The woman there isn't a witch—just a widow who lost her daughter to winter cough and now owes the Breath-less a debt she'll never repay. She gives Quinn bread still warm from the oven, salt from her own pouch, and boots far too large, stuffed with moss to keep them on.

The Hearth-Menders will meet you at the ford.

They aren't a coven with altars or oaths—just women with clay bowls and lullabies sung in low harmonies who know one truth: injury obligates repair. A village that burns owes the living a future.

The widow doesn't speak as she hands over a needle and thread. *Braid my hair*, she says. Quinn's fingers fumble—her hands shake from running—but she does it. The widow's hair smells of woodsmoke and lye, coarse under Quinn's palms. When the last knot is tied, the woman touches Quinn's wrist. *Now you are not just a girl running. You are someone who gave something. That is harder to forget.*

IV. The Hearth-Mender's Kitchen

The longhouse is deep in the eastern pines, where smoke from the central fire never fully clears. Quinn is given a stool by the flames and a sack of speckled beans to sort. She doesn't

Speak their tongue—not the words, but the rhythm of the work. They don't ask her story. They hand her a wooden spoon and nod toward the bubbling pot.

For three days, she sorts beans and listens. The women talk in fragments, voices low but clear: a lantern line broken near the ford, a girl smuggled out of Galanina with bread tucked in her shirt, a Daughter who refused to cut a dying man's last thread. They don't whisper. Secrecy, they believe, is just another debt—the more you hide, the more you owe.

On the third night, Mother Hemlock—the oldest, her back bent like a question mark—sets a bowl of thyme soup before Quinn. Steam curls up, carrying the scent of earth and crushed herb.

You can hear plants, Hemlock says. Not a question. A statement, soft as ash.

Quinn nods. Her throat is tight.

That is not a curse. It is a witness. The wheat screamed because it was afraid. You heard it. Now you must tell someone. That is the work.

Hemlock doesn't say what to tell, or to whom. But Quinn understands, in the wordless way twelve-year-olds grasp truths too big for names, that her gift isn't for hiding. It's for *carrying*.

That night, she leans over the hearth and whispers the wheat's scream into the flames. The fire crackles—once, twice—then settles. The women nod. They've heard it before.

Witness: Bryn, the Wetnurse (The Hooked Testimony)

Call the witness: Bryn, former wetnurse to Lady Margot, first wife of the accused.

The gallery parted slowly. In the wavering torchlight a woman in threadbare grey robes leaned on a knotted staff and moved toward the bar. Her steps made no sound on the stone. As she passed, an inexplicable chill brushed the faces of those nearest; candle flames dipped, then steadied, as if uncertain they should still burn. Her left hand ended not in flesh but in a brass hook—rough, forged from a farmer’s rasp, still scarred by the fire that had shaped it. The hook held a faint, cold iridescence, like the sheen on still water before a storm.

Her face was a map of old grief, skin drawn tight over sharp bones. Yet when her eyes found Aldric they burned with a light that had not dimmed in forty years—steady, cold, and unmistakably aware. Behind her, the polished marble reflected only the torches; she cast no shadow. No breath misted the air before her lips.

Elodie: “State your name and relation to the accused.”

Bryn (voice thin as winter ice, yet clear; it seemed to come from somewhere)

“I am Bryn. I served as wetnurse to his first wife, Lady

Margot, and to their daughter, Eleanor. I was midwife when she died.”

Aldric’s counsel (rising, a sneer in his tone): “A servant’s testimony from forty years past? The woman is ancient, her memory clouded by age and spite. Moreover, the Baronet held pit and gallows on his own land. Any discipline he administered there is not subject to this court’s review.”

Elodie (after a long pause, her gavel resting on the bench):

“The court will hear the witness, though the baron’s right to enforce law on his holding is noted. Proceed.”

Bryn’s good hand reached into her grey robe and drew out a silver locket, tarnished but still whole. As she lifted it, the torchlight seemed to retreat from the metal, and the air around her grew still and cold—the cold of deep water, of a fog that does not burn away.

“Margot gave me this on her deathbed. ‘For the child,’ she said. ‘The one who still breathes.’ Aldric never asked for it. He never visited her grave. I left his service in disgust. Three days later his men found me at a waystation. He accused me of thieving – of stealing this locket, which he had never once mentioned while his wife lived. He did not ask. He just swung. He

laughed and said the hand was enough; I could keep the ‘trinket.’”

She raised her brass hook toward the bench. The light caught its rough surface, and for an instant the hook glowed with a faint, cold fire—like the reflection of a moon that no one in the room could see.

“This was forged from a farmer’s rasp, at a forge that no longer stands. The hand that fed his children, that held his dying wife’s head – he took it for a trinket he had forgotten existed. I left the Cord behind. But I do not forget. Neither does the law, if it has the courage to remember.”

A heavier murmur passed through the gallery. Some nodded; others looked away. Aldric’s counsel objected again, citing the baron’s right of pit and gallows. Elodie, after a whispered consultation with the clerk of the *Codex of Precedents*, ruled the testimony admissible only as character evidence; the baron’s disciplinary authority on his own land could not be challenged by the Queen’s court. The substance of the accusation—the loss of Bryn’s hand—was dismissed as beyond the court’s jurisdiction.

But the locket remained on the evidence table, its tarnish catching a stray spark that seemed to linger after the torch’s

flame had faded. Bryn did not weep. She lowered her hook and limped back into the gallery, her eyes never leaving Aldric's face. He did not look at her. He could not. Yet his lips twitched into a thin, almost amused smile, as if he sensed something unspoken in the cold that followed her out of the hall.

VI. The Silk-Weaver's Attic

The last safe house is a Lethai-ar silk-weaver's cottage in the Crimson Valley, where the air hangs thick with the scent of boiling cocoons and mulberry leaves. The weaver—Mask-Quill—doesn't speak to Quinn for three days. Each morning, a bowl of steaming soup appears on the rough-hewn table. Each evening, she takes the empty bowl away, her silk sleeves whispering against the wood.

On the fourth morning, she sets down the spoon beside Quinn's untouched soup. *What is your name?*

Quinn.

No. That name is ash. Choose another.

Quinn stares at the soup—thyme floating in the broth, releasing its sharp, green scent as it cools.

Thyme, she says. My name is Thyme.

Mask-Quill nods. She cuts a strip of deep-red silk from her loom and ties it tight around Quinn's wrist. The silk is warm from the loom, alive with the hum of silkworms. *This*

is a witness cord. It will remember the truth of you, even when you forget.

She doesn't say what the truth is. Thyme does not ask. She is twelve. She has watched her village burn. She has crossed a black river on a Daughter's boat. She has learned that the world runs on debts she didn't incur but must repay anyway.

She will not forget the smell of thyme.

VII. The Bitter Root

The root that feeds is the root that binds. The
hand that rocks the cradle is the hand that
sharpens the knife.

— —from the *Book of the Unnamed*,
forbidden in Thepyrgos

Thyme will grow up in the Crimson Valley. She will learn to weave silk so fine it holds light like water, and to tie witness cords that remember what the mind tries to forget. She will never see her mother again. She will never know that Old Mira's last curse worked: the Lanterns' report described a girl with brown hair and no name, and the Inquisition closed the case six months later.

But she will keep the red thread on her wrist. And when she is old enough, she will join the Hearth-Menders. Not for

revenge. For *care*. Because someone has to stir the pot.

The soup is free. The second bowl will cost you a story.

She braids her hair with the same red thread—now faded to pink—and thinks of the widow's hands guiding hers, long ago.

Chapter I

The Second Hearth

She stirred the pot. She watched the pot.
They never saw her add the salt.

——Morwen of Thornwood, on the
occasion of no thanks whatsoever

I. The New Baronet

Thornwood is a village of sixty souls, a mill, a ford, and a Hearth Witch named Morwen. For thirty years she has mended bones, settled disputes, and kept the Hollow from the door. She asks nothing but a bowl of soup and a place by the fire. The villagers do not thank her. That is fine. Thanking is not why she does it.

Then the crown appoints a new Knight-Baronet: Sir Aldric of the Eastern Marches, a man with a hunting hawk, a young wife, a sickly infant, and no understanding of hedges. He arrives in a carriage that founders in the ford. His escort tramples the miller's bean field. He does not apologize.

Morwen watches from the kitchen door of her cottage, her thumb pressed against the jamb where the red thread hangs.

She already dislikes him.

But it is the wetnurse who makes her blood run cold.

The woman is tall, dark-haired with a single silver thread at her temple, efficient in a way that feels practiced rather than worn. She moves like someone who has attended many births and many deaths, but her eyes flicker when she thinks no one is watching—as if she is measuring the weight of her own obedience. She wears the plain grey robes of the Cord, yet the fabric sits loosely on her shoulders, as if she is still learning how to carry it. Her own set of scales for measuring milk sits beside the hearth like a second altar, but she never touches them without a glance toward the door, as though waiting for permission.

Her name is Sister Bryn.

You're of the Cord. I heard stories.

—Morwen, the first night

Stories are debts. I'm not here to pay yours.

—Sister Bryn, the first night

II. The Cold War

The baronet's household is a small court: Sir Aldric, his wife Lady Margot, newly pregnant, the infant Eleanor, a cook, a groom, and Bryn. Morwen is not part of the household. She is the village witch, which means she is expected to help when things go wrong and to stay out of sight when things go right.

The cold war begins with small things.

Bryn reorganizes Morwen's herb stores *for efficiency*, though she pauses over the mugwort, as if wondering whether the old ways still hold power. Morwen misplaces Bryn's witness cords *to air them out*, a small act of quiet resistance. Bryn salts the well water—just a pinch, not enough to taste, only enough to make Morwen's divinations cloudy. Morwen ties a red thread around the kitchen door—a [Warm Hand] working that makes the room feel too hot for anyone wearing a Daughter's grey.

Neither woman speaks of it. The baronet notices nothing. His wife, Lady Margot, notices everything but says nothing. She has learned that silence is the only armor that fits.

III. The Broken Fence

The first crisis arrives not with fire or fever, but with a fence.

The baronet's prized hunting hawk escapes its mews and kills a villager's goat. The villager—a widow named Quinn,

weary with an infant granddaughter—demands compensation. Sir Aldric offers a silver coin and a sneer. Quinn refuses. She goes to Morwen.

Make him pay, witch. He thinks we're
nothing.

—Quinn, her hands still stained with the
goat's blood

Morwen knows she cannot curse the baronet. The Chain-Lanterns are watching—not here, not yet, but they will come if a noble dies of a “witch’s fever.” She needs another way.

That night, she finds Bryn already standing at the broken fence, running her fingers over the splintered wood.

You're not going to curse him, Bryn says. Too risky.

No. But I need him to understand the debt.

Bryn is silent for a long moment, her gaze distant. Then she takes a length of red thread from her sleeve—the Cord’s cord, the kind that records grievances. *A witness cord. He won't see it. His wife will.*

Together, in the dark, they tie the cord around the baronet’s carriage axle. Not a curse. A *record*. Every time the axle turns, the cord whispers the widow’s name. Sir Aldric will not know why, but he will dream of goats for a week.

In the morning, he sends a purse of silver to Quinn’s door. He does not apologize. He does not know why he did

it.

Morwen and Bryn do not speak of it. But when Morwen returns to her cottage, the kettle is already warm. Bryn has been there.

You didn't have to help.

— — Morwen

The goat was not your debt alone.

— — Bryn

This is the first thread that binds them.

IV. The Infant's Fever

Lady Margot's baby, Eleanor, is a sickly thing. She coughs, she does not gain weight, she sleeps too much. Morwen has suspected for weeks that the child has a weak heart—something no poultice can fix, only careful nursing.

One night, the fever spikes. Lady Margot comes pounding on Morwen's door at midnight.

Please. She's burning up.

Morwen goes. She brings feverfew, a silver spoon, and her own mother's lullaby. She finds Bryn already there, holding the infant, her face as still as a mask, though her fingers

tremble slightly where they brace the child's back.

The two women work side by side. Morwen cools the child's forehead with a damp cloth while Bryn measures out drops of a grey tincture. Neither speaks. The only sounds are the infant's ragged breath and the soft chime of the baronet's hunting clock in the next room.

At dawn, the fever breaks.

Tincture of willow bark and a drop of your
own blood. You're funding the Cord with
her survival.

— — Morwen, accusatory

And your lullaby is a prayer to Iaea. You're
binding her to gratitude she'll never be able to
repay. Same coin, different face.

— — Bryn, equally accusatory

They stare at each other across the crib. The infant sleeps, her cheeks pink for the first time in weeks.

I didn't do it for the debt, Morwen says.

Neither did I. But the debt accrues anyway.

V. The Missing Child

The winter that follows is harsh. Margot, her belly large again, is knitting a red blanket. The ford freezes. The mill's water-wheel cracks. Three villagers come down with a lung-sickness that Morwen recognizes as the SPREADING—a Daughter's curse, she is sure of it. But Bryn tends the sick alongside her, and the sickness fades without a single death.

Then a village child—a girl named Pella, seven years old, curious and quick—wanders into the woods at twilight and does not return.

The baronet organizes a hunting party. Morwen knows the forest; Bryn can read the Hollow's attention. They go together, leaving the men to thrash about with torches.

They find Pella at midnight, sitting by a standing stone, unharmed. The Hollow was *just looking*, the girl says. *It was lonely.*

Morwen takes the child's left hand. Bryn takes the right. They walk out of the woods without speaking. Behind them, the standing stone hums once, then falls silent.

VI. The Winter Kitchen

The baronet throws a feast at midwinter—roasted swan, spiced wine, a fire so large it eats a month's worth of wood. He does not invite Morwen. He does not thank Bryn. He does

not notice that the food on the table came from the village's stores, or that the wine was watered, or that the servants are wearing the same coats they wore last year.

In the kitchen, Morwen stirs a pot of soup for the villagers who were not invited. Bryn portions the bread.

You're not so useless, Morwen says.

You're not so sentimental, Bryn replies, though her voice lacks the edge it once had.

They drink a cup of small beer. They do not toast. They do not smile. But they do not glare.

The red thread on the kitchen door. Did you tie that?

— — Bryn

I thought you did.

— — Morwen

Neither woman unties it.

VII. The Thaw

Spring comes. The ford opens. The baronet receives a letter recalling him to court—something about a border dispute, nothing that concerns him. He leaves his wife and child be-

hind. He does not say goodbye to the village.

Lady Margot, to everyone's surprise, asks Morwen to teach her about herbs and knots. *I want to be useful*, she says. She arrives with her half-knitted red blanket draped over her arm—the wool still damp from last night's rain—and sits closer than before, her fingers moving instinctively over the yarn as she speaks. Morwen agrees, on the condition that Bryn teaches her about the Hollow in return.

The three women eat together once a week: Morwen, Bryn, and Lady Margot. Margot's blanket grows stitch by stitch between them, its red threads catching the firelight like a third, quiet voice. They do not become friends. Their conversation is the conversation of people who have seen too much to pretend. But they build a small, fragile thing: a community that is not based on blood or marriage or feudal obligation, but on the simple recognition that *someone has to do the work*.

VIII. The Final Scene

One evening, as the last snow melts, Morwen finds a single red thread tied between a chair leg and the pot handle. She knows she did not tie it. She knows Bryn did not tie it.

She leaves it there.

When Bryn comes to fetch the soup pot, she sees the thread. She pauses, her hand hovering over the pot's han-

dle, as if weighing whether to cut it or leave it. Then she lifts the pot, the thread stretching taut between the chair and the handle, and pours two cups of tea instead of one.

Margot does not reach for her cup immediately. Her eyes drop to the blanket in her lap—nearly finished, the last few stitches loose and waiting—and for the first time, her knitting stills. She waits until Bryn’s fingers close around the second cup before she reaches for her own.

The soup is free, —Morwen, pushing a cup across
the table

The price is never, —Bryn, taking it, her voice
quieter than before

They drink in silence. The pot simmers. The thread holds. Margot’s needles rest in her lap, the red wool warm against her knees.

The Naming of Stones

We leave offerings. We don't ask who left them. We take what we need and leave what we can. It's not a cure. It's just... holding.

— — Village elder, unnamed

Thyme comes to the village at dusk, when the light turns the dust to gold and the air smells of woodsmoke and wet stone. There is no sign, no gate—only a milestone at the crossroads, its face worn smooth as a river stone by wind and time. Where a name should be carved, there is only a shallow depression, like a held breath.

She dismounts from her borrowed mare and runs her fingers over the hollow. Not erased. *Unmade*. As if the village chose to forget its name, or the Curse took it and left only the shape behind.

A woman steps from the tall grass at the field's edge. Her hemp bracelet is frayed to individual threads, each one catching the last light. She carries a basket of dried figs and a waterskin, but her eyes are on Thyme's wrist—where the red thread from Mask-Quill's loom still circles, faded to the color of old blood.

"We don't remember what we were called," the woman

says. Her voice is low, like stone grinding on stone. *"Only that we are still here."*

Thyme nods. *"How do you survive the Curse?"*

The woman gestures toward the village center, where a standing stone rises from the earth like a broken tooth. Pebbles, bread crusts, a single red thread are tucked into its cracks. *"We leave offerings. We don't ask who left them. We take what we need and leave what we can. It's not a cure. It's just... holding."*

Thyme touches her own thread. It feels warm from the day's sun.

"I'll stay three days," she says. *"I walk the roads. If I find anyone out there, I'll bring them in."*

The woman's lips twitch—almost a smile. *"The roads bring us what we need. Sometimes that's a stranger. Sometimes it's a mirror."*

She turns and walks back toward the village, her bare feet silent on the packed earth. Thyme follows, the mare's reins loose in her hand.

Episode One: The Man Who Cannot Speak

Thyme finds him on the third loop of the old Imperial Road. The same broken milestone (a jagged tooth of stone), the same scorched oak (black fingers against the sky), the same silence where a bird's call should be. He walks with his head down, shoulders hunched as if carrying a weight only he can

feel. His lips move constantly—shaping words that never leave his mouth.

She matches his pace without speaking. After a mile, he stops at the milestone. His hand trembles as it touches the chipped letters. *Regret. Hunger. The Same.* He presses his forehead to the stone, eyes closed. A muscle jumps in his jaw.

Thyme sits beside him in the dust. She takes a piece of white chalk from her pocket—leftover from Old Mira's gift—and draws a single vertical line on the stone's face. Not a name. Not a plea. Just a mark. Like a stitch holding fabric together.

"*You don't have to say it aloud,*" she says, her voice low enough that only he can hear. "*You can leave it here.*"

He doesn't look at her. But he doesn't walk away. His fingers trace the chalk line once, twice. Then he pulls a small knife from his boot and etches a second line beside it—parallel, deliberate.

That night, Thyme brings him to the village. She doesn't tell the elder his story. She asks only for a bowl of nettle soup and a space by the fire. He eats slowly, his eyes on the flames. Afterward, he takes a scrap of bark from the kindling pile and scratches a word into it with his knife: *Sorry.* He folds it small and tucks it into the milestone's crack, next to the red thread and a crumbling piece of barley bread.

He doesn't speak for the rest of Thyme's stay. But he stops walking the loop. Instead, he sits by the village well at

dawn, watching the mist rise over the fields. Sometimes he touches his throat, as if checking if the stone is still there.

Episode Two: The Mother Who Cannot Forget

Thyme finds her on the road to the burned orchard at first light. The trees are skeletal sentinels, their branches clawing at a sky the color of bruised plum. The ground is still black in places, ash crunching underfoot like frozen blood. She walks the perimeter slowly, her bare feet leaving no prints in the dust. In her arms, she carries a bundle of fallen branches, arranging them into a loose circle at the base of the oldest oak.

Thyme kneels beside her without a word. She picks up a snapped twig and adds it to the circle. The woman doesn't startle. She just shifts her stance to make room, her movements sharp and precise—like she's measuring angles only she can see.

They work in silence for an hour. The circle grows, taking shape—not a door, but a low, wide arch. When the woman's breath hitches, Thyme doesn't look up. She keeps weaving, her fingers finding the natural breaks in the wood, fitting them together like bone to bone.

At last, the woman stops. She steps back, her hands braced on her knees. "*It's not a door,*" she says, her voice raw. "*It's a grave marker.*"

Thyme nods, still crouched. "*Then you know where she*

is.”

The woman doesn’t answer. But that evening, as Thyme shares bread with her by the orchard’s edge, she does something new: she stops setting out the porridge. Instead, she lights a single beeswax candle in the child’s empty room and throws the window wide open to the wind. The flame bends but does not go out.

Thyme sees her press her palm to the doorframe for a long moment before walking away—not toward the village, but deeper into the ashes, where the wild thyme has begun to push through the blackened earth. She kneels and touches a sprig, her fingers lingering.

Episode Three: The Girl Who Cannot Stay

Thyme finds her at the triple split where no road is marked, only three worn tracks vanishing into different kinds of trees: one into pine shadow, one into sun-baked scrub, one into mist-shrouded alder swamp. The girl—no older than twelve, her hair the color of wet clay—is kneeling at the exact center, arranging pebbles in a slow, widening spiral. She hums a tune that curls and unfolds like a fern, no clear beginning or end.

Thyme sits cross-legged at the spiral’s outer edge, a respectful distance away. She doesn’t hum the girl’s tune. Instead, she finds the counterpoint—a low, steady drone that lives in the spaces between the girl’s notes. It’s not harmony. It’s *accompaniment*.

She takes a smooth river stone from her pocket—cool from the stream where she washed her hands that morning—and places it where the spiral’s next turn would begin, if the girl wished it to continue.

The girl stops humming. She tilts her head, one ear toward Thyme. Her eyes are pale gray, almost silver in the flat light. She studies the stone for a long moment. Then, with a finger that doesn’t tremble, she nudges it half an inch clockwise—just enough to make the spiral flow inward instead of out.

Thyme nods. She adds another stone where the new turn would begin. The girl watches her place it, then shifts her own pebble to close the gap.

They build the spiral in silence for twenty minutes. Thyme never leads; she only ever answers. When the girl finally stands, she doesn’t look at Thyme. Instead, she walks to the village’s standing stone—the same one with the offerings in its cracks—and presses her palm flat against its surface. She leaves a single pebble at its base, placed precisely where the shadow falls at noon.

The village elder sees this from her doorway. She doesn’t call the girl back. She simply fills a small bowl with water from the well and sets it beside the stone at dusk, next to the bread crust and the red thread.

Resolution

On her last morning, Thyme walks to the standing stone before the sun clears the ridge. The three offerings are still there: the folded bark scrap (*Sorry*), the candle stub (now a pool of wax holding a single wick), the pebble in its precise spiral at the girl's feet. The red threads flutter like wounded birds in the wind.

The elder joins her, her frayed hemp bracelet catching the light. "*You didn't cure anyone.*"

Thyme shakes her head, her gaze on the girl's pebble—small, ordinary, perfect in its placement. "*No.*"

"But they're still here."

"Yes."

The elder touches the milestone where the village's name used to be. Her finger traces the shallow depression where letters once lived. "*We've forgotten what we were called. But we haven't forgotten how to be together.*"

Thyme looks down at her wrist. The red thread from Mask-Quill's loom is frayed at the ends, the color washed to the pale pink of dawn. She unties it slowly, feeling the silk catch on her skin like a memory.

She kneels at the stone and ties the thread around its base—low enough that the girl can reach it, high enough that it won't drag in the dirt. It lies atop the girl's pebble, beside the man's bark scrap, beneath the elder's red thread from the

hearth.

“Then this is your name now,” Thyme says. *“The place where threads hold.”*

She stands. The elder doesn’t try to stop her as she walks toward the road that doesn’t loop—not for her, not anymore. Behind her, the stone waits. The threads wait. The village wakes to the sound of a loom beginning its work somewhere in the distance—not binding, but beginning.

Thyme doesn’t look back. She knows the thread will hold.

Epilogue: The Weaver's Promise

Years later, in the loom's hum and the steam of the dye pots, Thyme feels the ghost of that widow's hands guiding hers as she braids her own hair with faded pink thread. She thinks of the wheat's scream, swallowed by fire and whispered into flame. She thinks of Bryn's quiet hands lifting a soup pot, the thread stretched taut between chair and handle.

Some debts are not paid in coin or courage, but in the quiet insistence of showing up—again and again—for the ones who cannot show up for themselves.

She ties off the last thread. The shuttle clicks. The pattern holds.

And somewhere, a woman in grey robes pauses at a well, touches the red thread at her wrist, and pours two cups of tea instead of one.

Somewhere else, a girl with frayed pink thread at her wrist watches her mother's hands move over a loom—the same motion that once bound now begins.

The Milestone Mending

Speaking the Name: Mutual Aid in Action

When a character names an unspoken truth to relieve another's burden:

- **Speaker gains:** +1 die to the next action addressing that burden (e.g., healing, mediating, providing aid).
- **Listener gains:** NAMED condition (+1 die to acts of vulnerability; -1 die to acts of self-defense; lasts until they speak their own truth in return).
- **Former enforcer (if applicable):** Guilt of past enforcement (-1 die to acts of authority over the listener; lasts until they perform a visible act of restitution).

Restitution requires: A visible, narrative action that directly addresses the burden's origin (e.g., publicly acknowledging complicity, labor repairing harm, surrendering an enforcement tool). The GM confirms completion when the action is *observed and acknowledged* by those affected.

When restitution is complete, the Guilt penalty converts to a permanent COVEN BOND String (+1 die to aid that specific

person/faction).

Note: Naming the truth always triggers the narrative expectation of confrontation (GM describes Listener's reaction). Mechanical effects (Speaker/+1, Listener/NAMED, Former enforcer/Guilt) apply regardless of roleplay depth. Restitution is player-driven; the GM only intervenes if Speaker claims completion without observable action.

Bitter Root Condition

A character who has survived state violence and been smuggled to safety may acquire BITTER ROOT:

- **+1 die** to acts of mutual aid (feeding, sheltering, healing others).
- **–1 die** to acts of self-advocacy (asking for pay, demanding recognition, refusing a burden).
- **Prune** by an act of witnessed rage (public accusation, broken tool, screamed truth)—converts the condition to a permanent COVEN BOND String (+1 die to aid that specific person/faction), removing the –1 die penalty.